Introduction

A Note from the Author

I don't know about you, but I never felt like I fit in at work. Don't get me wrong, I'm driven to do great work, grow as an individual, and achieve at a high level. But when I arrived on the corporate scene as an Innovation Consultant for a Fortune 300 Insurance company in my 30's, it felt like I was on another planet.

The office environment was everything I should have wanted. Open and collaborative, it had high end glass whiteboards in every room and $5,000 big screen monitors to accompany each breakout room for all the virtual meetings we could handle. Each of us was equipped with a state of the art $1,000 standing desk, Apple monitors for our laptops and a $500 standard issue Herman Miller Aeron chair. Everything a new employee would want. All good so far.

Our mission was corporate innovation, a burgeoning industry term with a lot of buzz. We were working with startups on new technologies, driving process change and even trying to build new, innovative products and services. But under the hood, all the big corporate problems still existed: petty competition, slow decisions, backstabbing, turf protection, unclear priorities and lots of waste of time AND money.

What started as an exciting new chapter turned into a slow death march for me. I began to see how everyone around me was drinking the Kool-Aid (or pretending to be). I saw how critical problems and ideas were dismissed or glossed over, and how my typical days were drained of creativity even in the "most creative" area of the business.

I was sucked into politics, "lunch and learns," gigantic meetings where I didn't have a voice, and higher ups who cared more about style than substance. As I slipped more and more into malaise, I no longer saw a professional growth path at the company (or at least anything I was interested in). Everyone was just marching forward with a smile on their face like we were all living in Who-ville. I increasingly felt like I was in the movie *The Matrix*, and I needed a way out. But how? I had a wife, three kids under seven years old, a mortgage, and a lifestyle to maintain.

If I was going to figure this all out, I needed space. I needed to be left alone at work, get my shit done, and have time to plot my next move. So that's where my journey to Time Sovereignty began—at my standing desk in a plush office. I had no idea where it would take me.

Chapter One

Unplugging From The Matrix

As a corporate misfit, I've always seen the world through a different lens. Maybe it's the ADHD or maybe I'm just hyper-sensitive to understanding the 'why' behind what we do. Why is there so much fake work? Why do companies bring fourteen people into a meeting? Why do we make project reports sound like a win when they're really not? Why am I saying yes to everyone, but saying no to myself? Why did I just binge that plate of nachos after work?

As a coach who guides people through major career and life changes, I've observed that the greatest obstacle to change isn't motivation, desire, or talent—it's the countless distractions. How often have we wanted to make a change, but a month, year, or decade goes by and there's been no movement. We WANT to take action, but we ALLOW our time to be consumed by every ding, buzz, or "urgent" priority (usually someone else's). Then we rationalize by telling everyone how busy we are.

Do you know what the biggest distraction of them all is? Comfort. The norms. The processes. Social conformity. It's like everyone is running around operating some default program with no higher understanding of if the programs they are executing actually matter. The default view is that our time has a static value—the more we can do, the better, period. This is why we take calls at our kids' bedtimes and why we see caffeinated, stressed out soccer moms speeding their kids between practices while texting. It's all in the name of productivity.

This is not a time management book. In fact, I'd refer to it as an "anti-time management" book. This book represents an alternative to conventional time management approaches that operate on the assumption that while time is limited, all tasks hold equal importance. The conventional view treats time management like a game of Tetris: arranging blocks of time as they fall, trying to fit everything into the right spaces. However, the very process of managing time has become yet another source of distraction on top of all the obvious distractions of apps, notifications, and alerts.

I'm not going to pile on here. Instead, I will guide you through a framework for valuing your time differently according to context, and give you strategies to help you take the reins of your time in a way that works for you. When re-framing our time, it is necessary to also re-frame our mindset. My hope is that this book will introduce you to a different approach to productivity that will help you to take control of your time and your goals. It's time to step outside of time management and step into time sovereignty.

What is *The Matrix?*

In the 1999 film *The Matrix,* life seems normal. Crowds of busy professionals walk the streets of a big city, getting to their next meeting or appointment. The main character, Thomas Anderson (Keanu Reeves), has a normal office job in a normal cubicle. But he's also a cyber hacker who goes by the name *Neo.*

[Spoiler alert incoming] Neo inherently feels that something is wrong. Everyone around him seems to be operating in mundane ignorance of the world around them. They are rote, repetitive, and lifeless.

Neo finds Morpheus*,* a man who has also been looking for Neo. Morpheus gives Neo a choice to see the truth. He is offered a blue pill or a red pill. The blue pill allows him to rejoin the matrix and it becomes his reality again. He could wake up like nothing ever happened. But taking the red pill, Neo would see the truth and gain the perspective of what is possible outside of the matrix.

Despite his fear, Neo's quest for the truth pulls him to take the red pill. He discovers that humans are living in a simulation created by AI to harvest humans as an energy source. More importantly, he discovers that outside the matrix, the normal rules don't apply. He becomes The One, who harnesses all of his abilities in reality to save the humans and destroy the AI.

Like Neo, everyone faces a choice: continue operating within familiar constraints or gain a broader perspective that reveals our true capacity for controlling our time. While most of us must work, we retain the power to choose how we allocate our hours and what we prioritize.

You face this choice now: you can take the blue pill and close this book and continue on with your day. Or you can take the red pill and continue reading and you will see how calm, focused, and purposeful your days can be.

Your Comfort Is In The Way

Congrats! You took the red pill. You've chosen to lean into the possibility that you can own your time and use it differently than everyone else. But guess what? Putting these pages into action will cause some discomfort. The habits, routines, and cultural norms you've been conditioned to are likely deeply ingrained. Choosing to think differently is one thing. Choosing to *ACT* differently is another.

When people realize they can operate differently, they often worry about how others will perceive them because it is likely that their peers, colleagues, and even partner are still "in the matrix." Most prefer fitting in to standing out. However, by employing strategic approaches to

time sovereignty, individuals can actually enhance their impact and be viewed as intentional, disciplined leaders. This shift in perspective unlocks unprecedented progress, control, and confidence in professional endeavors.

But this shift requires that you step outside your lowly comfort zone. Any change inevitably brings discomfort, but discomfort is the price you pay for the change you want. The comfort zone is the enemy—an artificial limiter keeping us in the matrix. Why? Because people are naturally predisposed to weigh direct experience more heavily than potential possibilities. Therefore, if we only do what we know, we can not take the right chances to experience something better. This sensitivity to the downside or the unknown is a fundamental miscalculation. Through this book, I will show you that uncertainty exists on a spectrum, and embracing new approaches doesn't require becoming an excessive risk-taker. Many successful entrepreneurs I work with are inherently conservative and risk-averse, but they do consistently take small actions that expand their comfort zone.

The Trap Of Modern Work

Since the Industrial Revolution, business has centered on two words that I can't stand: efficiency and optimization. Yes, I know, that may sound crazy in today's world. However, these words are why we all feel trapped, chasing our tails while more and more gets piled on with no end in sight. The organization of job functions, development of specialized skills, defined career pathways, and even benefits have stripped us of our autonomy while claiming our time as *theirs*. Our educational system reflects this structure, presenting students with predetermined professional tracks that suggest clear, linear progression.

As the economy grew, it gave us cultural markers of success: job titles, promotions, increasing compensation, luxury vehicles, expansive homes, and country club memberships. While these achievements aren't inherently problematic, they've become the default mental model for a successful life. In accepting this model, people often unconsciously accept its hidden consequences—the unspoken expectation of 80-hour workweeks, the obligation to take on work beyond their scope, and the sacrifice of personal time.

Making these compromises may seem trivial at first. However, over decades they often culminate in what we traditionally call a midlife crisis. I frequently work with professionals in their forties, fifties, and even sixties who realize they've spent decades focusing on the wrong priorities: someone else's. Many feel that they don't have a good definition of the success they were even chasing in the first place. This leads to a ton of regret. They desire to do something more impactful and creative while having more freedom and control over their time. Untangling these challenges becomes exponentially more complex when complicated by existing lifestyle commitments, family responsibilities, and financial obligations.

The price of not claiming sovereignty over your time accumulates silently, but then compounds all at once. Think about your availability for work. It didn't seem like a big deal to

answer your boss's late night email, but now you're responding to emails at the dinner table and taking calls outside of what any sane person would call "normal business hours." Years pass with you rationalizing "always available" because it seems like a cultural norm. Most people eventually get to a level of discontent, but can't quite understand the magnitude. They may see their kids clamoring for their attention, but only getting it in fragments. They may feel drained at the end of the day with little vitality for anything else, but just chalk it up to, "I'm sacrificing for them." They may finish a big project at work, feel a rush of accomplishment, but then wonder whose vision this was and was it all worth the effort? They may even start to ask, "What is it all for?" but never go any deeper because everyone else seems to be plodding along and going through the same motions. It always feels safer in a crowd.

Then one day the simmer of discontent boils over in a moment of clarity: "I've invested twenty years of time and energy into someone else's dream. When will I start mine?" This is what I call a BREAK moment. This is the moment you can't unsee. These moments frequently emerge in my coaching practice where clients struggle with regret over decades of unexamined choices. Many acknowledge mentally disengaging from their careers years before taking action to change their circumstances. What really kills them is the idea that all they needed to do was become a bit more sovereign over their time allocation. That hits hard, like a punch to the gut. While it's never too late to reclaim control of one's time, the lost opportunities for growth and fulfillment cannot be recovered.

The challenge lies in creating a sense of urgency before crisis points emerge, whether personal, professional, or emotional. By understanding and actively managing this dynamic earlier, professionals can avoid the painful awakening that often arrives decades into their careers. This understanding points to the necessity of a more comprehensive approach—one that addresses not just the mechanics of time management but the fundamental relationship between time, value, and personal development. We need a framework that creates not just efficiency but the mental space necessary for meaningful growth and direction-setting.

This realization led to the development of my framework called The Houdini Formula, a systematic approach that moves beyond traditional time management to establish true time sovereignty. Rather than simply fitting more tasks into limited hours, it creates the space needed to question, explore, and ultimately reshape our relationship with time itself. We will break down the tenants of The Houdini Formula later in this book. In the meantime, I thought my personal story would be helpful here.

A Personal Journey to Time Sovereignty

My path to understanding time sovereignty emerged from an unconventional career trajectory. Unlike many who follow predetermined professional paths, mine was more of a feeling than a path (and a very loose one at that). In college, I specifically remember one conversation with my dad that went like this:

DAD: “So, what’s the plan?”

ME: “I have no idea what I’m going to do, but I feel like I will do a bunch of different things and find success.”

To this day, I have no idea why or how I felt that way, but that’s exactly what I said. This feeling helped me stumble my way through many roles. I was a banker. Then, a financial derivatives trader. I went back to school. I started a business that failed. Then, seemingly oblivious to my failure, I opened my own “startup consulting” business—whatever that means. I have worked in many settings, from venture-backed startups to a Fortune 500 insurance company.

Each of these experiences revealed a common thread: despite achieving conventional success in many ways, something big was missing. I wasn't leveraging my core talents or creating the impact I believed I was meant to create. This realization came to a head during my corporate tenure with a Fortune 500 insurance company. I was appalled at the bloat. The non-work. I witnessed countless hours consumed by political maneuvering and unproductive meetings that added minimal value to products or outcomes. And here I was getting paid well to just sort of go along with it all. *Was this it?*

There were a couple of BREAK moments during this time that caused me to take radical control over my time. The first came while I was leading a high profile project by helping a subsidiary company build an internal “innovation” team. In my mind, I was the behind-the-scenes Navy SEAL getting all the logistics right to execute a mission, but the internal team should get all the credit. We worked hard and did some amazing work I am proud of. Then one day, my boss’s boss was pissed. He just came from a leadership meeting where my counterpart at the subsidiary presented all the amazing work we had done. There was just one problem: I wasn’t standing on stage presenting with him. I started getting questions like: *“What percentage of this project can WE take credit for?”* Maybe it’s the misfit in me, but that just didn’t sit well. *Was this it? Is this how I want to spend my time?*

The second BREAK moment came during a one-on-one meeting with my boss. He’s a great guy and we are friends to this day. He sat me down and said: “Mike, we pay you a lot of money. I need you to fight the bureaucracy. I need you to engage in these battles we have.” At that moment, I distinctly remember one of my favorite quotes popping into my head from one of my favorite authors, Nassim Taleb, of *The Black Swan* fame. Here’s the quote: “The three most addictive things on earth are heroin, carbohydrates, and a steady paycheck.”

This moment clarified for me the misalignment I was living between “how we do things” in an organization, and the meaningful contribution towards real results we all want to create. That contribution, that life I wanted—I wasn’t going to get it there. I needed to take control. I needed to design my professional life around conditions that would enable my optimal performance as both a professional and an individual.

I couldn’t just quit. I had a family to think about. So, I began implementing practices to reclaim control over my time, allowing me to invest in figuring out what I wanted and developing my business vision. This involved learning to decline commitments diplomatically, presenting these decisions as win-win scenarios that benefited both myself and the organization. I developed strategies for managing my availability, blocking calendar time effectively, and coaching colleagues on communication methods that enhanced productivity. This was the beginning of development of my framework for time sovereignty called The Houdini Formula.

The results proved counterintuitive. Not only did I gain time to invest in my future direction, but I also became more valuable to my organization. My focused presence and clear boundaries earned recognition, and I observed similar patterns with coaching clients who often received promotions after implementing these practices. This revelation showed me how conventional approaches to time management often work against individual and organizational interests. As luck would have it, because of the time I reclaimed in 2018, I not only got out of my corporate prison, but now I get to bring ideas like this to the world. I am living the future I designed back then.

Chapter Two

The Great Time Heist

Before we jump to the tactics, it's important to understand how modern work steals our time and actually benefits from keeping us frantic and fragmented. Modern work structures have engineered what I call "The Great Time Heist"—a systematic approach to acquiring our most precious resource through an exchange of future dollars for present time. This transaction fundamentally shapes how we value and allocate our hours, often to our detriment. It's the proverbial carrot always dangling in front of us, while the stick is ready to slap us on our behinds.

Modern organizations established the salary. This is a compensation structure that assigns specific dollar values to our time, whether $50 per hour or $500,000 per year. The first trick is that salaries provide plenty of comparison data points for our neurotic minds to latch onto. "I'm worth $150,000 per year." "Oh, but Jimmy is worth "$250,000 per year." These valuations become deeply ingrained in our professional identity, so much so that we flex to the outside world to get validation in return. Then, of course, we're promised increased earnings potential through prescribed organizational behaviors that lead to promotions or bonuses (the carrots). By prescribing one accepted value on our time, this cultural norm disguises the true economics of time in two critical ways: the potential value we could create by leveraging our time differently, and the personal worth of our time beyond professional contexts. The true value of time, therefore, is malleable.

The generally-accepted economics of time's value leads to a cascade of tradeoffs that we make unconsciously. Consider how roles evolve: we often accept positions that align with our aspirations, only to find the daily reality diverges significantly from the initial description or expectations we had. Yet we persist, justifying our continued engagement through the lens of hourly compensation or sacrifice to get the next promotion. "Ok, I'll do that because I'm getting paid the same." Or, "If I do this and show I'm a team player, I'll surely be at the top of the list for Director." This mindset transforms us into employees that default to yes, accepting additional responsibilities simply because they fall within our compensated hours. The more damaging issue is when we allow work to encroach on our personal lives where it is easy to justify prioritizing work over family obligations and personal development because that time is not compensated and is viewed as worth $0 per hour.

The Productivity Paradox

It's comical to me how the modern workplace needs us to be productive, yet perpetuates us being unproductive. The culprit? Distraction. Organizations widely acknowledge the challenge of workplace distraction, with studies indicating that 92% of professionals view it as a significant concern. However, rather than addressing the root causes, many organizations respond by increasing demands on employees' attention and availability. New systems are

added. New processes designed to streamline and organize. New apps and software to manage our productivity. If we have a productivity problem, then the answer must be that we must control productivity with more systems! This leads to more notifications, more reports, more compliance, and more *distraction.* And round and round we go. There's this perverse incentive for organizations to not allow you to have any more agency over your time. Like I said, it's rather comical.

Take the remote work debate during the COVID-19 pandemic to illustrate this dynamic. While many employees reported increased productivity (and better overall satisfaction) when working from home, most organizations were scared shitless. They added Zoom meetings about Zoom meetings. If your calendar wasn't full, well, then you weren't working. How about eye movement and keyboard tracking software loaded up on your laptops? That just led to software that randomly logged keystrokes to avoid the overlords. How messed up is that? Your take-him-or-leave-him, mostly chill boss became the micromanager from hell. And God forbid you set Slack to "unavailable" at 9:00 pm.

If the corporate approach to time management is insane (it is), then our personal approaches and conventional wisdom isn't much better. It basically amounts to applying bandaids to a gaping neck wound. While popular methodologies like the Pomodoro Technique, Eisenhower Matrix, and various productivity applications may help reclaim incremental minutes so you can line up more Tetris pieces in your calendar, they miss the broader challenge of evaluating whether our efforts align with our long-term development and highest impact potential.

These traditional approaches focus almost exclusively on maximizing output within each hour (productivity). Think: how do I compress this oversized task list into my standard workday? Through extensive experimentation and obsession with time management systems, particularly given my background managing ADHD, I've discovered that while they may offer tactical improvements, they consistently fall short of addressing our core need: what should I use my time for?

Time management approaches say nothing about how we understand if we are working on the right things—the things that have massive leverage and can bend the value curve of time. Bending the value curve of time doesn't require us to do more. It doesn't require us to be productive. It requires us to be *effective.* Being effective is largely counterintuitive. To be effective, we must do less, but better. We must create slack—often twenty to fifty percent—in order to invest in strategic thinking, skill development, and career acceleration.

The True Cost of Context Switching

One of the most insidious productivity destroyers is context switching: the cognitive cost of transitioning between different tasks. While often overlooked, its impact is substantial. Consider email habits: the average professional checks their email 10-15 times daily (according

to Matt Plummer in Harvard Business Review), requiring about 23 minutes on average to refocus on their original task after each interruption (according to a study by UC Irvine). This translates to hours of lost productivity daily.

The primary obstacle between professionals and their goals isn't typically motivation or willpower—it's the absence of systems that enable sustained focus. The constant interruptions from email notifications, chat messages, SMS alerts, impromptu desk visits, and unstructured communication create a fragmented workday that prevents deep work. A three-hour block of focused time delivers substantially more value than the same duration broken into shorter segments. This fragmentation particularly impacts complex projects that require sustained attention and creative problem-solving.

This scattered attention approach creates a cycle of dependency and burnout. Employees, fearing negative consequences, adopt a "yes" mentality and remain constantly connected. This pattern serves organizational interests by reducing turnover and minimizing the need for meaningful career development discussions. However, it comes at a severe cost:

- Diminished time for rest and rejuvenation
- Limited capacity for strategic career planning
- Reduced creative thinking and innovation
- Loss of individual agency and sovereignty
- Increased stress and mental fatigue

The system perpetuates itself through fear—fear of job loss, fear of change, fear of standing out. Organizations benefit from this dependency, using productivity concerns to justify increased control while simultaneously creating conditions that undermine true productivity. Breaking this cycle requires recognizing these patterns and implementing systematic changes to protect focused work time.

Time Renters vs. Time Owners

This false perspective of the nature of time value creates two distinct camps when it comes to time management: time renters and time owners. Time renters—representing approximately 80-90% of professionals—believe they have an abundance of time and view their time as a commodity to be sold at a fixed price. They have skills that command a market price. They accept a standard work week and benefits. Time management is the practice of fitting all the tasks, demands, and work given to them within that work week. A time renter’s only path to increasing their income is through productivity (doing more) or new skill acquisition. However, this approach often leaves them without the capacity to invest in developing new capabilities.

Time owners, conversely, believe their time is finite, like a stockpile of gold. They consider not only the present value of their time, but also its future potential, blocking time for activities that could exponentially increase their impact, earnings, and happiness. They

therefore think strategically about their time as a resource to be invested, regardless of whether or not they are on the clock. Their goal is to be *effective*, not productive.

A time owner recognizes four key principles for maximizing their time's value:

1. The value of time is different based on context (personal, professional, future).
2. Time (and money) invested in the right things today can be 100x more valuable than their standard rate.
3. Elimination is a secret weapon.
4. Schedule slack is essential for energy management and alignment of vision.

Time owners recognize that not all hours carry equal potential for value creation. They focus intensively on high-impact activities that leverage their unique capabilities, delegating or automating lower-value tasks, or simply saying no. This approach allows them to narrow their focus while exponentially increasing their impact.

The real power of time ownership emerges through the compounding effect of strategic time allocation. By concentrating on activities where they excel and create distinctive value, professionals can dramatically increase their per-hour impact. This increased productivity creates a virtuous cycle: greater value creation leads to higher compensation, which enables the reclamation of more time through strategic outsourcing or automation. This principle applies equally to corporate professionals and entrepreneurs. Corporate leaders who adopt this mindset become more intentional and focused, maximizing their impact in key moments. Entrepreneurs can leverage it to build systems that deliver value without constant personal involvement, creating space to focus on their highest-value contributions.

The Great Time Heist continues unabated in most organizations, but understanding its mechanics provides the first step toward reclaiming sovereignty over our time. By shifting from time renter to time owner, we can break free from the conventional exchange rate of time for money and begin building a more intentional, impactful professional life. If you’re still with me, it’s time to become time sovereign.

Where Great Ideas Go To Die

I’d like to close this chapter with another personal story, meant for anyone who has pitched a brilliant, value-producing idea to an organization only to be laughed out of the room. Unfortunately, it’s a very deflating story, but one that illustrates how difficult it can be for a time owner to work in a time renter world.

Back on the “innovation” team at that Fortune 500 insurance company I mentioned earlier, I encountered a common organizational challenge: the prevalence of large, time-consuming meetings that seemed to multiply without regard for their true cost. Now, I’m biased, because I hate meetings with a passion. However, I saw an opportunity to solve (what I

thought was) a real problem. I raised my hand for a project I thought was worth my time and our team's effort to do meaningful work and drive true change. You know, the work we ALL hope that we will do in our career. Even though my proposal was dismissed with extreme prejudice, the idea would later be validated by one of technology's most forward-thinking companies.

I regularly attended meetings with fourteen people that had no agenda, no outcomes, and no tangible next steps. Half the room or more wouldn't have anything substantive to say. They'd just nod along and act like they were paying attention. The misfit in me thought this was a problem. I wondered how much money this billion dollar behemoth was wasting annually across the company.

Enter: **the meeting cost calculator.** The idea was to create an internal application to track the cost of meetings and get people to think twice about who they invited and why. We could potentially save millions of dollars and increase our productivity!

The pitch was simple: Our team would build a software tool to serve two primary functions. First, it would calculate the direct cost of meetings by analyzing:

- Participant attendance
- Individual compensation levels
- Estimate an hourly rate for each person
- Time duration

Second, and more innovatively, it would translate these costs into metrics directly relevant to the company's core business. Rather than expressing meeting costs in a dollar figure, which had no real tangible comparison, the system would convert the total meeting cost into something our business knew the value of: an insurance policy. This way we could ask, "Is this specific meeting worth two entire years of homeowners insurance premium from one customer (about $2,000)?"

Consider a two-hour meeting with ten participants, resulting in a total cost of $5,000 in employee time. Instead of presenting this figure in isolation, the calculator would express it as equivalent to 5 homeowner's insurance policies (at $1,000 each). This translation would incorporate additional context, such as:

- Customer acquisition costs
- Sales cycle duration
- Downstream revenue implications
- Resource allocation trade-offs

The aim was to make the opportunity cost of meetings immediately tangible to decision-makers, transforming abstract, default time expenditure into concrete business impact. Despite its potential for driving organizational efficiency, the proposal was initially met with laughter. Many viewed it as a critique of the corporate culture rather than a practical tool for

resource optimization. Needless to say, little old me couldn't get that project over the finish line. Ultimately, I decided that the hassle of advocating for such an obvious idea would be like shoving an ice pick into my left eye.

Fast forward to July 12, 2023. You can imagine my elation and vindication when I opened up CNBC.com and read the headline "Shopify rolls out tool that tallies up cost of unnecessary meetings." It seems there actually is a market for good ideas that save time, money, and attention, after all.

Shopify's Chief Operating Officer Kaz Netajian summed it up this way: "People ask questions. What is this meeting for? Why are there so many people in it? And those questions will put an immense amount of pressure on organizers to organize fewer meetings—**and leave the rest of us alone**." Makes pretty good sense to me, and very aligned with this book!

This case study illuminates several key observations about the time ownership mentality inside corporate environments:

1. Most people are still operating in the default mode of "not rocking the boat."
2. Time ownership takes guts. Otherwise, just put your head in the sand with everyone else.
3. Any great idea (outside the lines) will face resistance, even when addressing widely acknowledged problems. It's not you, it's them.
4. There is a market for people who value time and think outside the box. It just might not be in your current corporate culture.
5. The true value of time remains poorly understood in many organizations.

While I am happy to see this idea be implemented, it is clear that most traditional workplaces are severely lacking when it comes to embracing the output of their employees' time sovereignty. Unfortunately, this places the onus on the individual to change the corporate view of time from within the organization. To understand how to do that, you have to dig a little deeper into what it means to be time sovereign.

Chapter Three

Time Sovereignty

When you think about time freedom, what comes to mind? Is it doing whatever you want? Laying on a beach somewhere not having to work? Or maybe not having to answer to anyone? Whatever your definition, we can all agree that we want more control and autonomy over how we spend our time. We want time sovereignty.

Time sovereignty is a mentality more than anything else. It is a mindset shift that requires an individual to:

1. Understand their time is finite
2. Value time not in terms of a fixed dollar amount, but instead in terms of what they want and future possibilities
3. Take action that protects that finite resource so it can be invested towards its highest use

It is easy, as an employee, to get stuck in the idea that all tasks cost the same because you are paid the same amount per hour worked. Time sovereignty asks us to consider that the value of an hour is not equal across all tasks.

Time Sovereignty vs Time Management

In Chapter One, I introduced the difference between time owners and time renters. But even time owners get sucked into the seductive allure of the time management trap. Time Sovereigns, on the other hand, do not. If time management is like playing Tetris—a frantic scramble to fit all the pieces together before everything falls apart—time sovereignty is like enjoying a slow, effortless puzzle with your grandma on a breezy Sunday afternoon.

Time sovereignty represents more than a management technique; it's a fundamental shift in mentality that enables professionals to reclaim not just their hours, but their agency in directing time and energy toward their highest purpose. This framework creates space for a four-step process:

1. Observing current patterns and behaviors
2. Orienting oneself to possibilities and priorities
3. Letting go of the unimportant
4. Acting on strategic priorities

The fundamental question driving this journey was whether I was becoming the best version of myself—a universal aspiration of human nature that often remains unexplored when we accept default patterns without question. By developing strategies to manage time more

effectively within existing constraints, I inadvertently created a blueprint for others that are looking for a similar transformation.

This approach extends beyond productivity enhancement. When we feel out of control with our time, it diminishes our confidence, increases anxiety, and reduces our presence in important moments. Conversely, establishing agency over our time improves our relationships, impact, and professional presence. This newfound agency over your time creates a foundation for broader life changes, whether that be launching a business, pursuing independent work, or exploring new horizons.

The journey to time sovereignty begins with questioning established norms and designing intentional strategies to operate within existing systems while gradually transforming them. It requires moving beyond the reflexive acceptance of traditional time management approaches to create space for meaningful work and personal development.

True productivity transcends the simple optimization of minutes and hours. It requires something more fundamental: the space to be explorative and follow the path where we can create the biggest impact. Traditional time management approaches, with their focus on tactical efficiency, cannot deliver this broader perspective. They may help us do more things, but they rarely help us do the right things. The goal isn't to optimize every minute but to create room for strategic reflection, personal recovery, directional reorientation, and deep thinking about long-term objectives.

The Science of Deep Work

Traditional time management approaches often fall short because they focus on optimizing minutes without addressing the fundamental conditions necessary for meaningful work. The science of deep work reveals why these surface-level solutions prove inadequate and points toward more effective approaches.

The Cognitive Foundation

Research demonstrates that task switching can reduce productivity by up to 40%. This striking statistic emerges from our limited cognitive bandwidth; the human prefrontal cortex possesses finite capacity for decision-making within a given day. This limitation explains why leaders like Mark Zuckerberg adopt practices such as wearing the same style of clothing daily: to preserve cognitive resources for more important decisions.

Neuroplasticity and Skill Development

The brain's neuroplasticity—its ability to form and strengthen neural pathways—responds powerfully to sustained attention. Extended periods of focus literally reshape our neural architecture, enhancing our capacity for value creation, productivity, and creativity.

The Role of Automaticity

Skill development follows a pattern from the struggling beginner to being able to perform a skill automatically. This is a process known as automaticity. While this same mechanism can entrench default behaviors in our lives, we can harness it intentionally through deliberate, focused practice. This explains why sporadic, fragmented attention proves ineffective for mastering new skills: the brain requires sustained engagement to develop automatic processes. This biological process requires approximately fifty hours for basic competency in a new skill, with expertise demanding significantly more time.

Energy Management and Ultradian Rhythms

Contemporary research increasingly recognizes the importance of natural energy cycles, which typically last 90 to 120 minutes. These ultradian rhythms create periods of peak cognitive performance, suggesting that productivity optimization requires managing not just time but energy. Rest periods between deep work sessions prove essential for maintaining high performance.

The implications of this research are clear: productivity isn't just about managing discrete time blocks but about aligning our most challenging work with our natural energy peaks. This understanding informs how we structure our days and when we schedule our most important tasks.

How Elon Musk Values Time

No matter what you think of Elon Musk, he is extremely productive and effective. He simultaneously runs three large, complex, high-growth companies (Tesla, SpaceX, and now X). He runs several other projects that push the technological envelope (Neuralink, The Boring Company, and Starlink). And to top it all off, he’s tackling government waste with DOGE. Elon is not a model for balance or family values, but there is much we can learn from his approach to time management.

As it is explained in his biography, *Elon Musk* by Walter Isaacson, Musk is obsessed with urgency, working on the single most important bottle neck problem every single day, seven days a week. His metric is "burn rate" (the daily cost of operations) compared to future revenue potential.

Here's how it works: Musk would say, "In ten years, SpaceX will earn $10 million per day. Every day we are late means missing out on that potential revenue." Through this lens, Musk does some unconventional things. For example, he wouldn't bat an eye at chartering a jet for $90,000 to get a critical part to the field if it saved a day of work, but he'd veto buying a $2,000 part if he thought it could be bought cheaper or manufactured in house for less.

The key here is the frame of the future earnings potential. While most of us operate with budgets to control cost today, these actually constrain our ability to make quality decisions for the future. We miss great opportunities to invest time or money today that will make things easier or more attainable in the future.

Elon being Elon, he doesn't stop there. In a company email leaked in 2022, Musk outlines basic rules for productivity to his employees. Interestingly, at least to yours truly, not a single one is about doing more. In fact, they are the polar opposite—they're about elimination.

Elon Musk's 6 rules for time management at Tesla:

1. **No large meetings.**

   Musk says, "Excessive meetings are the blight of big companies and almost always get worse over time. Please get off all large meetings, unless you're certain they are providing value to the whole audience."

2. **No long or frequent meetings.**

   Musk says, "Get rid of frequent meetings unless you're dealing with an extremely urgent matter. Meeting frequency should drop rapidly once the urgent matter is resolved."

3. **Leave meetings.**

   A Forbes' article sums it up this way: Musk recommends that people "walk out of a meeting or drop off a call as soon as it is obvious you aren't adding value. It is not rude to leave, it is rude to make someone stay and waste their time."

4. **No acronyms or jargon.**

   Musk says, "Don't use acronyms or nonsense words for objects, software, or processes. In general, anything that requires an explanation inhibits communication. We don't want people to have to memorize a glossary just to function." His principle is that by eliminating over communication, everyone communicates more effectively.

5. **Ignore the chain of command.**

According to Musk, employees should ignore the chain of command. "Communication should travel via the shortest path necessary to get the job done," he says. "If, in order to get something done between departments, an individual must talk to a manager, who talks to a director, who talks to a VP, who talks to another VP, who talks to a director, who talks to a manager, who talks to someone doing the actual work, then super dumb things will happen."

6. **Use common sense.**

Finally, Musk says, "In general, always pick common sense as your guide. If following a company rule is obviously ridiculous in a particular situation, such that it would make for a great Dilbert cartoon, then the rule should change."

While these principles may seem radical within traditional corporate structures, they address common frustrations and inefficiencies that professionals regularly encounter around bureaucracy. Putting aside Musk's legendary workaholism, wouldn't you want to work in a culture that abides by those fairly basic and common sense rules?

The challenge, it seems, is that the systems and procedures created in the name of "streamlining" and "efficiency" have produced perverse norms that actually *prevent* true productivity. These norms are so ingrained and so accepted culturally that applying some semblance of common sense can get you labeled a misfit, or worse, fired for coloring outside the lines.

So what does that all mean for us, the common sense, wanna-be time sovereigns? The decisions we must make are less about what to do, but *how* we implement rules to take back our time, and make it all *feel* like we're adhering to the status quo culture.

In the next few chapters, I will show exactly *how* I escaped the corporate distraction vortex, and how my clients who are taking control over their time continue to just be left alone so they can focus on their deepest, most meaningful work.

I'd like to close this chapter with a thought experiment, Albert Einstein-style. Einstein was famous for his thought experiments. In his day, there was really no way to get hard data on quantum physics, but he succeeded in cracking some of the hardest nuts through the power of his imagination.

So what would happen if we applied this mentality to our careers and even our lives as a whole? Let's say you currently earn $100,000 annually, but you want to reach $250,000 within five years. The default, time renter person would probably take small steps with low urgency and if they got the bump in five years, they'd call that a win. Given the chance to accelerate that timeline, the time renter would probably look at the money cost in relation to their current personal budget and current income, making any outlay of money scary. After all, what if it

doesn’t work? Furthermore, a time renter would look at any time investment through the lens of their current tasks, current schedule, and current lack of time.

However, the time sovereign understands she can use time and money for future gain, provided the gain is big enough and has a reasonable chance of working. Now throw Musk’s “future earning potential” frame into the mix. If you could wave a magic wand and make $250,000 tomorrow, your net gain would be $750,000! What would you pay to accelerate your time table? Even if you did it a year early, that’s $150,000 extra in your pocket. How much time could you carve out of your “busy” schedule to make that happen?

Chapter Four

The Houdini Formula

Named after the legendary escape artist Harry Houdini, this formula provides a systematic approach to breaking free from the constraints of traditional time management or the default corporate schedule requirements. Just as Houdini mastered the art of escape, I developed this framework to enable professionals to create space for focused work and meaningful progress. In this section, I'll provide an overview of the formula; each element will get a deeper dive later on in this book.

Core Elements of the Formula

Know Your Priorities And Advantages: The foundation begins with clear identification of priorities and personal advantages. This requires honest assessment of where you can create the most value and impact, whether at work or in pursuit of broader goals.

The Scarcity Principle: Counterintuitively, strategic unavailability can enhance perceived value. By carefully managing your accessibility, you can increase both your productivity and your professional standing.

Communication Channel Ownership: Taking control of communication patterns involves more than managing messages—it requires engineering entire channels around your energy cycles and work preferences. This means establishing clear expectations and protocols for how and when you engage with others.

Strategic Upward Management: Effective management of supervisory relationships centers on proactive communication designed to address leadership anxiety. By providing structured, comprehensive updates, you reduce the need for micromanagement while building trust and autonomy.

Calendar Blocking: Implementing focused work periods requires more than simply scheduling time—it demands creating inviolable spaces for deep work. These blocks should align with your peak energy periods and most important priorities.

Making "No" a Win-Win: Declining commitments effectively requires framing refusals in terms of mutual benefit. This approach preserves relationships while protecting your time by demonstrating how alternative allocations create greater value for all stakeholders.

Environmental Engineering: While complete control over your work environment is impossible, you can optimize your space and schedule to support peak performance. This includes aligning complex tasks with your natural energy cycles and creating conditions conducive to focused work.

In summation, The Houdini Formula isn't about escaping work—it's about escaping the inefficient patterns that prevent our best work from emerging. By implementing these principles systematically, professionals can create the conditions necessary for meaningful achievement while maintaining positive organizational relationships.

Chapter Five

Know Your Priorities And Advantages

When's the last time you seriously sat down and thought about what you want out of your career? Your life? Do you have that vision written down, or are you daydreaming about it after work or in the five free minutes you get between kids' activities?

The point of becoming Time Sovereign is creating the space to seriously strategize the most important things in life, so you have higher odds of attaining them. The first step is articulating clear objectives for your reclaimed time. Maybe it's a side venture, engineering a career transition, or positioning yourself for promotion. This clarity creates a hierarchy for decision-making and brings intention to time allocation.

So what are your priorities in life right now? Jot them down. They don't have to be perfect, we can always iterate on them. If you had more time, how would you use it? Kids, family, volunteering, side business? Take a shot at articulating them right now, and why you want them.

The next step toward becoming Time Sovereign is accepting responsibility for directing your reclaimed time to serve those priorities. Doing this requires clarity about your unique advantages and ways you can create the most impact per unit of time. Then you can leverage those advantages in the most effective way toward your goals. While the desire for more free time is universal, this framework specifically addresses professionals seeking meaningful advancement.

Beyond conventional skill development, truly effective career navigation requires understanding your complete set of advantages. Warren Buffett's "circle of competence" concept—focusing on what you know with certainty and leveraging it for increasingly valuable activities—provides a starting framework. However, my Advantage Mapping process extends far beyond mere competence to encompass:

- Natural curiosity and genuine interest
- Personality alignment
- Support systems
- Learning preferences
- Decision-making styles

When you pair a high-level view of our true priorities with a comprehensive view of your personal advantages, new paths and strategies emerge for us to get what we want most. For those still discovering their advantages, this framework creates space for essential self-exploration.

To learn more about my Advantage Mapping process, visit https//:michaelgardon.com

If you struggle with big questions like, “What do I want?” and “What am I uniquely good at?”—here’s a helpful hack. Flip the question. Ask: “What do I absolutely *not* want?” This problem-solving approach is called inversion, and it’s been used for centuries in the sciences. I first heard of it from Charlie Munger, Warren Buffett’s billionaire business partner, and I’ve been using it ever since to solve problems. When you begin with what you don't want, you narrow your options set, and it can reveal your underlying values.

For instance, when I contemplated my career change in 2018, I was clueless about the path out. It was overwhelming. Then I asked myself: “What am I unwilling to tolerate anymore?” The answers to that question helped me narrow down what type of business I wanted, and how to design it.

As for Charlie, his famous example of inversion is this quote: *“All I want to know is where I’ll die, so I’ll never go there.”*

Chapter Six

Time-Blocking

Now it's time to get tactical. If you read the headline and are considering skipping this chapter, don't. This isn't your run of the mill time-blocking that the "experts" teach you. This is a whole new way to imagine and integrate *you* at your best to create more time, more impact and more leverage in your day to day. Chapter 6 comes with a supplemental pdf you can download at michaelgardon.com/resources.

The Energy Calendar

The foundation of effective time blocking begins with understanding your natural energy patterns. Before you call me "woo-woo," think about it for a second. If you controlled your schedule, would you ever schedule staff meetings and "all hands" at 9am when your creative juices are flowing? Hell no!

I want you to build your energy calendar right now. Take out a piece of paper and divide it into three columns: "High Focus," "Lulls," and "Drained." Now, under each column, note approximate times of day that correspond to that feeling. There could be multiple in each.

Next, jot down the day to day activities you do on a regular basis. These could be checking email, TPS reports, client outreach, meetings, strategy sessions or anything else you do on a regular basis. When *should* you be scheduling those activities according to the focus level needed on your chart?

For me, I'm most focused and creative right away in the morning after I drop my kids off at school. So I plan all my writing in the mornings, and I reserve calls and client meetings for the afternoons. I've experimented a lot with when I work out, and right now I'm working out mid-day as a reset and to keep my energy as high as I can for my afternoon meetings.

Rather than viewing your calendar solely through the lens of time, consider it through the perspective of energy fluctuations. This approach requires careful observation of your natural focus periods, energy peaks, and necessary recovery times.

Your 'Perfect' Week

I can feel your doubt—you think the perfect week doesn't exist. Well, you're right, and you're wrong. While you don't have full control over your work schedule, you can start to design your perfect weekly rhythm and use it as a base to start making more sovereign choices over how you use your time.

Here, you will design your perfect week based on what you figured out in your energy calendar. Your focus should be on your work week, but go ahead and do the weekends as well. Doing this exercise sets the stage for how to ideally align your most important priorities based on *your* maximum productivity and impact.

I learned this method from medical doctor turned mega-YouTuber, Ali Abdaal (a true misfit!). This is the exact method I teach to high performing corporate execs who want more control over their time and energy. Here's how to do it:

1. **Create a blank calendar:** You can do this any way you want, but I use google calendar. Most digital calendars allow you to create a new labeled calendar. I named mine "perfect week."

2. **Theme your days:** Most of us have multiple responsibilities and priorities, so theming out days makes sense. Set your themes by 1) Priorities or 2) large areas of responsibility for your job. Here's what mine look like:

    a. Sunday: Revitalize
    b. Monday: Content Creation
    c. Tuesday: Program Design
    d. Wednesday: Distribution
    e. Thursday: Client Growth
    f. Friday: Future
    g. Saturday: Wander

3. **Add blocks for your perfect day flow:** Plan out each perfect day according to what you've learned about your energy and the activities that are top priority for you. I color code the blocks so they are easy to see and differentiate. A big key here is to add in blocks of time for space to create calm and transition your energy in order to manage the activities that you need to be paying attention to on a regular basis. Here is an example of my Perfect Monday:

    a. 5-6am: Future Visioning and Power up
    b. 6-7am: Content Engagement
    c. 7-8:30am: Kids and Transition
    d. 8:30-11am: Writing
    e. 11am-1pm: Workout and Lunch
    f. 1pm-4pm: Outreach, Connection and Networking
    g. 4-4:30pm: Powerdown and Plan The Day Ahead
    h. 4:30-8pm: Family time
    i. 8-10pm: Powerdown

Once you have your Perfect Week scoped out, it's time to implement. Be aware, this next step will be a powerful eye opener for you. For reference, here's my entire Perfect Week:

Implementing Time Blocks

Now that you have your “perfect week,” it’s time to operationalize it. Here’s where we step from dreaming to action. Now, look, you’re not going to be able to implement your perfect week 100% right away, BUT starting today you can start to protect large blocks of time you need for deep work—the kind that will get you where you want to be, instead of spinning from distraction to distraction.

Here are the key principles for effective time blocking to keep in mind:

1. Claim block periods of 90 minutes or longer when possible.
2. Protect these periods as untouchable, high-priority commitments.
3. Label blocks appropriately on your visible work calendar.
4. Align highest-value work with peak energy periods.
5. Schedule lower-intensity tasks during natural energy dips.
6. Overlay your “Perfect Week” template on your upcoming work week schedule.
7. Notice where your peak energy periods and perfect week activities overlap with the commitments, meetings and tasks you already have planned.
8. Copy over a couple of your high impact time blocks to your work calendar.
9. Start small. Take one action this week to move a lower value meeting or task out of one of your high impact time blocks. You’ll immediately begin to feel more free and in control.
10. Over time, you can get more proactive about protecting your time blocks as you get more confident and assertive.
11. Remember, we’re not aiming for a 100% perfect week! If you get 60-80% of it you’re doing great!

When designing your schedule within typical corporate constraints, begin by analyzing your current activity patterns and energy levels. While many organizations default to morning meetings followed by fragmented afternoon work periods, this structure may not be optimal for your performance rhythm. Understanding your ideal setup provides the foundation for thoughtful schedule restructuring.

The strategies in the rest of this book are dedicated to helping you push back and protect your time blocks! So don't worry if you feel like you can't move your schedule yet. We'll get there.

Advanced Time-Blocking

Once you've established consistent blocks for deep work, you'll begin to see many areas of your day you can begin to take back. Here are some common advanced strategies we teach. These advanced time-blocking strategies focus on the bookends of your schedule—creating intentional spaces for transition, planning, and rejuvenation.

PTDA: Plan The Day Ahead—consider blocking the final thirty minutes of each workday for next-day planning. This practice enables thoughtful prioritization and provides a clean break between work and personal time. In addition to planning, this time is for getting any open items out of your head and onto a list or plan for the next day, helping you forget about work and be more present as you transition home.

Your mornings are more calm and organized, because you already know the most important tasks you need to work on tomorrow and exactly what you are going to start doing when you hit the office. Similarly, creating a buffer at the start of your day can help transition from hectic morning routines to focused work. Rather than rushing directly into meetings or tasks, this time allows for strategic thinking and setting daily intentions.

"Double Count": Double counting is a strategy that marries a work task and a personal task or initiative together to kill two birds with one stone.

Here's an example: Most people feel too guilty (or too "busy") to exercise during the work day. You can "double count" by taking a walk outside while on a client call. There are plenty of AI recording tools and note takers for you to use. Similarly, you can schedule certain calls to do on your commute. Consider leaving the office early at 4pm and scheduling your status meeting on the ride home. There's no limit to the number of double count items you could pack into your day. As you begin to design your time, use your creativity from this new lens to double count everything, and watch your free time pile up.

20% Time: This approach draws inspiration from successful organizational practices like Google's "20% time" policy, which allocates one day per week for employees to pursue creative projects. While not every organization offers such formal policies, you can implement it for yourself with the double count system.

Is there a project at work you believe in, but it doesn’t have full buy-in yet from management? Maybe it’s personal to you, and you see the potential in it. Dedicate a time block to moving that initiative forward. By taking what seems like a small risk, you will likely catch the attention of higher ups, and you will likely feel more energetic, creative, and empowered for doing so. Even if that one project doesn’t work out, by compounding 20% time, you’ll eventually hit a home run.

This approach reinforces your position as a strategic thinker rather than simply someone avoiding obligations. By consistently framing decisions through the lens of organizational value, you establish yourself as someone who thinks critically about resource allocation. The ultimate goal isn't to do less—it's to create space for higher-value activities. When you demonstrate that your time allocation choices consistently drive superior results, you build the credibility needed to maintain control over your schedule.

Chapter Seven

Make “No” a Win-Win

“Okay Mike, I get time blocking, but my calendar is full. How do I get rid of the stuff already on my plate?” You start saying ‘no,’ but you make it a win-win. The foundation of time sovereignty rests on the ability to decline or redirect requests on your time effectively without rocking the boat. This isn't about becoming difficult, combative, or selfish—it's about framing decisions in terms of organizational value and optimal resource allocation.

Many workplace norms, from standing meetings to "lunch and learn" sessions, persist without careful consideration of their true cost in terms of lost focus and productivity. Effective leaders don't want passive order-takers; they want team members who think critically about resource allocation and organizational value.

Even seemingly fixed commitments, like recurring one-on-one meetings, become negotiable when approached thoughtfully. Rather than viewing these as immutable, consider them as historical decisions that can be optimized. When proposing changes, focus on the potential for increased value creation rather than personal preference. The key lies in moving beyond acceptance or rejection of requests to thoughtful evaluation of how time can be best invested for organizational success. This approach transforms potentially confrontational situations into collaborative optimization opportunities.

‘No’ isn’t a naughty word. It can and will actually work in your favor, but you have to do it right. There are three key psychological elements to making no a win-win:

1. Clear rationale for the proposed change
2. Specific value proposition
3. Presentation as an option rather than a demand

Real life example: When declining a meeting invitation, you might say, "I notice there are ten attendees for this discussion. Given my current projects and our timeline, I believe I could create more value by dedicating this hour to advancing our deliverables. I'm happy to review the meeting notes or provide input beforehand if needed. What are your thoughts on this?"

This framing accomplishes several objectives:

- Demonstrates thoughtful consideration of resource allocation
- Provides clear business rationale
- Offers alternative solutions
- Maintains collaborative tone
- Shows respect for leadership's perspective

Good bosses want people who can solve problems on their own, manage themselves, and make the best use of resources. Despite the fear we may have because our boss pays our salary, saying “no” can actually help your career, show initiative, and demonstrate that you can handle your work.

Saying no is an art. To help you can find a swipe file of over 100 ways to say no at work so you can be left alone at *michelgardon.com/resources*.

Chapter Eight

The Scarcity Principle

Now that you are blocking your time and understand how to make ‘no’ a win-win, it’s time to take your sovereign journey to the next level.

Have you ever noticed the high performer at your office is really hard to get a hold of? She seems to drift into the office and then disappear without a trace, only to return with a key part of the project nailed. Meanwhile, you respond to every email and every question your co-workers have, but are barely noticed.

Counter to the prevalent "always available" work culture, making yourself scarce can actually enhance your professional value. This principle is drawn from basic economics, like when items that are scarce go up in price. The principle defines the idea that selective unavailability paired with high performance can increase perceived value in the workplace.

There’s no question your coworker is an expert. But it’s not just that she’s heads down focused all the time. By being away, others *perceive* her as busy, focused, and unshakable. The key lies in selective presence: being fully engaged when present while maintaining strategic distance at other times. This creates a dynamic where your time and attention become more valued precisely because they are not constantly available.

Your co-worker can be out of the office with the boss off her back because she’s completing focused work in time blocks, but she’s also communicating results to the right people in the right ways. She’s an expert, and she’s left alone because of it. Good news! You can do the same thing with the Expert Positioning System.

The Expert Positioning System

Effective implementation of the scarcity principle requires three core elements:

Focus on Needle-Moving Activities

You need to understand that approximately 20% of activities drive 80% of results. This is called the Pareto Principle or the 80/20 rule, and it has deep mathematical truth to it across all domains. There are countless Youtube videos and books on the Pareto Principle, but what you need to understand is that the people who get left alone at work ONLY focus on the 20%, and they say ‘no’ to the 80% of activities that are distractions. This focus enables higher impact during periods of engagement while justifying selective availability.

Go back to your job description. Look at your compensation drivers. Or just have a one-on-one with your boss to clarify exactly where you should be focusing your effort within the 20%.

Result Communication

If you’re out of sight, you can’t just hope that your stakeholders know what you’re up to. You need clear, timely communication of outcomes achieved during focused work periods that validate your selective availability approach. This isn't about constant self-promotion but rather about ensuring value visibility. I’ll discuss how to do this in the next chapter, but for now just realize you need to advocate for yourself, what you’re doing, and what you’re delivering so everyone can get off your back.

Expertise Extension

Use your work to develop deeper expertise in your core domain. This can only happen if you let go of spreading attention across diverse projects, delivering on tasks that are out of your scope, and “being everything to everyone.” Extension reinforces your position as a subject matter expert in a smaller area so you can be known for something deep, while protecting your time from the distraction sharks out there. This specialized focus justifies selective availability while enhancing your professional value.

The scarcity principle only succeeds when built on a foundation of demonstrated competence and clear communication. Being selectively unavailable while delivering subpar results or appearing disengaged when present will undermine rather than enhance professional standing. That’s the entire goal of being time sovereign: be recognized as someone who focuses intensely on high-value activities and is recognized for their work, so that people leave you alone so you can create even more time and energy.

In the next chapter we break down exactly how to communicate your work when you’re not around so you get proper credit, earn trust, and are left alone to do your work.

Chapter Nine

Strategic Visibility

Strategic visibility serves as the essential counterpart to the scarcity principle. When you are present in the office and available, whether in person or virtually, that presence must be purposeful and impactful. This approach centers on managing upward communication effectively while establishing clear communication protocols with your co-workers.

Managing Upward Communication

Remember the goal? To be left alone, right? Well, who is usually looking over your shoulder? The boss! They need to know you are doing what you're supposed to, creating results, and surfacing problems in a proactive way.

Managing up isn't just about communicating your work, however. The art of managing up is primarily concerned with managing your boss's anxiety. You see, most managers don't desire to micromanage—they simply need confidence that projects are progressing appropriately because they have their own headaches to deal with. They have their own responsibilities, duties and people to answer to. So at the most basic level, managers need to trust that their people are on top of the work they ultimately oversee. What your boss really needs is project communication in an easy-to-access format that they can use to communicate updates to their boss without having to make changes, parse words, or lose context.

There are three major ways you can get better at managing up, getting your boss off your back, and freeing up more of your time.

1. The Weekly Status Doc

Creating systematic approaches to project updates can dramatically reduce ad-hoc interruptions while building trust. I found that with standard communication and cadence, you can actually train your boss on where they can go to find the exact information they need and leave you alone. Enter the weekly status doc. Here are the basic elements:

- Key highlights from the week in bullet form (at the top)
- Upcoming milestones and next steps (high level project map)
- Editorial context on weekly achievements (details and context)
- Current challenges or blockages
- Resource needs or leadership decision points
- Archive of past status docs (linked)
- Archive of reference material

To download the exact template I used at a Fortune 500 insurance company go to Michaelgardon.com/resources.

This approach serves multiple purposes: it demonstrates proactive management, provides readily shareable updates for upper management, and creates a searchable archive of project progress. Perhaps most importantly, it trains stakeholders where to find information independently, reducing the need for direct interruptions. Those 8pm emails and 6am texts for project status disappear.

2. The "1-3-1" Principle

We all despise the fire drills. A problem occurs and all of a sudden the microscope is on you, with everyone chiming in and sucking your time, energy, and attention away from what matters. Worse, with more cooks in the kitchen come more suggestions, more second guessing, and more blame.

Problems and setbacks are inevitable. When they occur, it's your chance to showcase how you handle them, and build trust in your process, so everyone gets off your back. But that's not what most people do. Let's take a look.

Because most of us are smart, highly educated overachievers, our bias is to deliver problems slowly, only once we've found the solution and have remedied the situation. But this degrades trust when communicating up. We have to let go of that perfectionism in order to accomplish something much greater—time sovereignty. Enter the 1-3-1 Principle. Here's what it is:

1. Surface the problem immediately. It might be 1 minute or 1 hour, but get it done with speed and urgency.
2. Surface 3 possible solutions (or hypotheses) to the problem.
3. Present your one (highest odds) recommended course of action.

Here's why this approach builds immediate trust, *and* takes less time:

1. You show you're not afraid to surface a problem and ask for help (most people are afraid).
2. Presenting 3 options shows that you've thoughtfully looked at the problem with the available information, aren't jumping to conclusions, and have an open mind for how the problem could be solved.
3. You are taking ownership of the problem by recommending your best approach to solve the problem, but asking your boss for their input.

The results? Nine times out of ten, your boss will approve your recommendation. Can you imagine how free and in control of your work you will feel with this process? Can you imagine how much time this can save you?

This approach builds trust by demonstrating both transparency, capability, and strategic thinking. It also leverages organizational resources more effectively by enabling early intervention when needed.

3. Take Control of One-on-One Meetings

I have a confession: one-on-ones are the bane of my existence. I don't know about your org, but the amount of times I've seen these "regularly scheduled" meetings get moved, shifted, or deleted just shows how low priority they end up becoming for most organizations. When they do happen, rarely is there a tight agenda, focus, or specificity. This just leads to more waste of time, lack of clarity, and little to no usable feedback. Your boss may have twelve of these every other week. You only have one, so take ownership of that time, because it's yours.

Rather than treating one-on-one meetings as passive reporting sessions, view them as opportunities to drive your professional development and project success. This means:

- Prepare a focused agenda
- Lead the conversation
- Seek specific guidance or perspective
- Discuss career development opportunities
- Follow up on action items

Using strategic visibility can help ensure that the time you spend on tasks in person has an impact, instead of spending your time sitting through arduous meetings or opening yourself up to off-task distractions.

Chapter Ten

Your Communication Architecture

Now it's time to get really tactical—and maybe a bit uncomfortable. The next stage of becoming time sovereign is all about setting firm boundaries. However, boundaries aren't just set once, they need to be communicated properly (so you aren't perceived as a difficult crazy person), and reinforced so everyone knows you're serious and why.

Train Your Colleagues With Communication Protocols

Now that you have mastered upward communication to get your boss off your back, the next step is to streamline communications with your colleagues and others. The idea here is not to accept the default way communication gets passed in your organization, but set effective boundaries for how *you* handle communication, and manage expectations. This starts with creating clear guidelines for different communication channels based on urgency and complexity.

Here is exactly how I trained my team. Remember, I wasn't the boss here. I was just an individual contributor on a team of high-functioning consultants in a very fast-paced environment. But I saw how the chaos of multi-channel communication was spreading me thin and wasting my time.

Things That Can't Wait

Notice how no one seems to call each other anymore unless they are traveling or it's your boss who needs something *now?!* Instead they use text, chat, or even email, but those are slow, especially if you're out of the office or heads down in deep work.

When I was out of the office (and I routinely was), I made sure my team knew they should call me on my cell if they needed anything right away. This way, I ensured they knew that I was available for urgent matters or questions even if I wasn't present. This also helped minimize the calls I got because, remember, no one likes to pick up the phone anymore.

Reserve phone calls for truly urgent matters requiring immediate attention. This creates a clear signal for genuine emergencies while preserving focus during normal operations.

Three Hour Issues

I know you've been there: you send a Teams message or Slack a coworker and anxiously tap your desk while you wait for a response, which may take seconds, minutes, or hours—all while your attention is split between the work you are doing and checking for a response. Or worse, you're getting dinged constantly from coworkers on issues that could be an email or a quick phone call. If you don't check the message right away, you'll be searching the thread later trying to piece the relevant information together and wasting time. Operating like this is a certainty that your day gets away from you.

Instead, let your team know that *you* use chat apps for anything that can wait up to three hours. That was the time frame I used, but feel free to use your own. I don't care what it is, just set the expectation, and watch how your time opens up.

The point is not to eliminate all back and forth over chat. Sometimes you will want to use this channel in a back and forth way. The point is *you* are taking control and setting up the comms to work for *you* while everyone else feels anxious each time they get a notification. You, on the other hand, feel free and in control.

Utilize chat or messaging platforms for quick updates requiring response within a few hours. This keeps rapid communication flowing without the overhead of email management.

You Now Check Email Twice Per Day

The email inbox is the biggest black hole in modern work. The average American office worker checks their email up to thirty times per day! Not you anymore. Here's how to handle email:

1. Let your co-workers know you check email twice per day. Do what works for you. I used 10:30am and 2:30pm. Put it in your email signature if you have to.

2. Establish that any email will be checked at those times unless it is marked as high priority.

3. For high priority emails, ask that your colleagues also message you or call you to note the priority. Here's a script you can send them: *"Hey, just sent you an email on [project]. Need you to respond ASAP please"*

I realize this type of directness can feel uncomfortable, but I guarantee your coworkers will respect it, and you just might see some of them implement your strategies as well!

How You Now Run Meetings

I don't care how everyone else runs meetings. *Your* time is valuable, so when *you* run meetings, *you* establish clear standards for meeting participation:

1. 60 and 30 minutes are no longer your default meeting time frame. It's 50 or 20. You need a buffer, and you signal time compression.

2. You create agendas. (Even if it's just a few bullet points, and even when you're not the meeting owner)

3. Define clear objectives and decision points.

4. Limit participation to essential contributors.

Let everyone else flail about, lose time, and stagnate project progress by not keeping tight meetings. You don't have time for that. You need to see your kids, get actual work done, or spend time planning for your future.

Tips For Implementing Your Comms Strategy

There is zero doubt that these strategies work, however this is the most uncomfortable part—telling people about your changes and seeing how they react. Here's how to introduce your new communication protocols without looking like a difficult employee:

1. Make the business case in terms of organizational benefit (we covered this more in Chapter Seven).

2. Frame it as an experiment: *"Hey, I think we've struggled with effective communication, and I've done some research. I'd like to implement some changes and see if there is any benefit that we could incorporate further on our team."*

3. Maintain flexibility for genuine exceptions.

4. Document and share successful outcomes.

5. Allow others to adopt practices voluntarily.

When you make the changes more about the org and others, people typically respond in a more accommodative fashion. When you own your time, and help others own theirs, it's a true win-win.

Chapter Eleven

Environmental Design

If you implement the strategies I've just outlined, you'll begin breathing easier, protecting your time, and most importantly: you'll be left alone so you can get real work done. Maybe even get out of the building more and spend less time on Zoom.

The next step toward consistently carving out time for deep work sessions aligned with who you want to be depends significantly on the environment in which they occur. Environmental design focuses on creating conditions that consistently enable peak performance and flow states, making these productive periods repeatable rather than leaving them to chance.

Success begins with understanding where and when you perform your best work. This requires careful attention to the environments where you find yourself most deeply engaged and productive. For instance, while modern open offices project an image of collaboration and innovation, they can be an enemy of focused work due to constant distractions and impromptu interruptions.

Consider my experience: Despite having access to a well-appointed office environment with the latest technology, glass boards, and standing desks, I discovered that coffee shops provided my optimal work setting for deep work. The combination of ambient activity and anonymity—where people are present but not directly engaging—makes ideal conditions for creative work. This insight led to a consistent routine of morning work sessions at a local café. It took some work managing up, but it got me out of the building and into a space for me to do my best work (and also build my side business).

The Elements of Environmental Design

Space: The physical environment should align with your work requirements and personal preferences. This might mean utilizing breakout rooms, finding quiet corners, or even working outside the office when possible. The key is identifying spaces that minimize unnecessary interruptions while maintaining comfort and focus.

Energy: By understanding your natural energy patterns and peak performance periods, you can schedule deep work sessions accordingly. This alignment of time and space creates a powerful foundation for consistent productivity. So what are some things that drive your energy and get you into flow? For me, it's a good pot of warm green tea (I've never liked coffee), reviewing my priorities, and good music (I use brain.fm or my own Spotify playlists).

Cues: Every high-performing athlete has a specific routine or set of cues they implement to signal their brain that it's time for focused work. Golfers use the same pre-shot routine. Baseball pitchers—same movements every time. Steph Curry—one dribble, shoots the free throw. As a high performing, sovereign corporate athlete you can and should do the same thing. Examples of powerful cues include:

- Specific audio environments (such as binaural beats or focused work music)
- Physical transitions (like walking to a particular location)
- Ritual beverages or snacks
- Consistent setup routines
- Self talk (something you say to yourself)
- A light workout (10 pushups)
- A call to a loved one
- A calendar reminder
- Computer focus mode

Any cues, when used consistently, become powerful triggers for entering focused work states.

Effective environmental design extends beyond immediate productivity gains. When we consistently create conditions conducive to focused work, we experience greater satisfaction and control over our professional lives. This reduces the likelihood of work bleeding into personal time, such as needing to complete projects during family dinner or bedtime routines.

The ultimate goal is compartmentalization—creating clear boundaries between focused work periods and other aspects of life. This separation enables both higher quality work and more present personal time, reducing the anxiety and scattered attention that often characterizes modern professional life.

Chapter Twelve

Escaping Yourself

While much of our focus has centered on managing workplace distractions, the principles of time sovereignty extend naturally into our personal lives. The challenge of digital distraction, in particular, requires thoughtful consideration of how we spend our time outside of work hours.

The Self-Sabotage Challenge

Humans excel at self-deception, particularly in justifying easy choices over valuable ones. We often rationalize time spent on social media or streaming services as "rejuvenation time" without honestly assessing whether these activities truly serve that purpose. Just be honest for a second. How often does five minutes of scrolling social turn into an hour for you? The path of least resistance—choosing the easiest available activity—frequently leads to hours lost in low-value pursuits, followed by regret and diminished self-esteem. The solution lies not in wholesale elimination of digital media or entertainment but in thoughtful curation of our information diet. This involves making conscious choices about what we allow into our attention space.

Curate Your Information Feed

Consider the long-term effects of the information you consume. Social media algorithms, for instance, can either enhance or detract from your flow state depending on how you curate your feed. By following sources that align with your aspirations and values—whether entrepreneurial insights, professional development, or personal growth—you can turn the distracting platforms into valuable resources.

To take time sovereignty further, take a hard look at the informational sources you are allowing into your world. You are the gatekeeper. Eliminate the low value news, the petty influencers, and make space for the highest quality sources that align with who you want to be.

Consumption Boundaries

Look, I watch a ton of TV (usually bingeing a show with my wife before bed), and I’m on social media a lot. These activities aren't inherently problematic, at all, but their impact (positive or negative) depends largely on intentionality and boundaries. As a time sovereign individual, you can’t let these activities consume more of your time than you want, or bleed negative effects into the areas of your life you want to protect most.

For example, I have a standing rule with my kids where any one of them is allowed to tell me to put my phone away at any time if they feel like I am not present. Designating specific times for entertainment while maintaining device-free periods for family interaction will enhance both experiences and help you escape some of the self sabotaging behavior that many of us feel.

The transition to time sovereignty in your personal life often follows successful implementation in professional contexts. Once you experience the benefits of intentional time allocation at work, the possibility of applying similar principles to personal time becomes more apparent. This might involve:

- Establishing clear boundaries for digital device usage
- Creating designated times for media consumption
- Curating social media feeds to align with personal goals
- Setting specific objectives for leisure time

Time sovereignty isn't the elimination of leisure or entertainment. Remember this is not a productivity book, and I'm not trying to turn you into a robot. But time sovereignty is about ensuring that our choices align with our values and aspirations. By taking sovereignty over our personal time, just as we do with professional time, we can create space for both meaningful work and genuine rejuvenation.

This mindset shift represents the true essence of taking the "red pill" from *The Matrix*. It means acknowledging our role as the creator of our daily experience and accepting responsibility for curating our attention. When we recognize our agency in these choices, we move from passive consumption to active creation of our desired life experience.

Chapter Thirteen

What Will You Do With All That Time?

The journey to time sovereignty begins with acknowledging a fundamental absurdity: the notion that our 18- or 21-year-old selves should determine our life's direction. While we must forgive those younger versions of ourselves for making the best decisions they could with limited information, we need not remain bound by those choices.

We live in what I call the self-directed renaissance—an era of unprecedented opportunity. Never before have individuals had such extensive access to tools, information, and reach to reshape their professional lives. This renaissance enables us to repackage our talents, skills, and advantages in ways that generate income while providing greater freedom and fulfillment.

Real Stories of Time Sovereignty Transformation

Nicole's Journey

Nicole was a burned out operations executive at a non-profit. Technically excellent and task oriented, she ran a team of twenty people, but was underpaid and always wondering, “Is this it?” Additionally, her husband ran into visa challenges to enter the US. They were living thousands of miles apart. Her priority was to join him, while setting up a business where she could work from anywhere.

Working with me, Nicole started to slowly take more agency over her time with the goal of creating enough space to focus on what she really wanted. Little by little, the principles in this book were applied, and she began making progress. Within a year, Nicole had even scaled back to part time because she had taken on a few freelance clients in the digital marketing space.

A few months later, Nicole left her job and moved to a remote island off the coast of Columbia with her husband. She continues to support herself through freelancing, and has created enough space to build a small farmette where they grow their own food. She even rescues abandoned dogs and gives them the home, food, and care they need.

Right now, Nicole is building her own coaching program that helps overworked and undervalued women reconnect with their inner peace and power to create the health, confidence, and alignment they’ve been searching for.

Next week, as I write this, I’ll be attending one of her virtual events. While not fully there yet, Nicole has found peace, happiness, and purpose through her work. Her creative energy is alive and the impact she is having is massive. She is doing what she wants to do and becoming who she is meant to be. She is time sovereign.

A Personal Testament

I started this book with my story of being stuck and directionless in 2018, and how I started taking more control over my time so I could invest that energy into getting out of corporate. But what I didn't share is what my life looks like today, after six years of compounding the time sovereignty I started back in that small cubicle.

Today, as I write this in early 2025, I'm sitting in a coffee shop in my home town. The baristas all know me by name (or order). The buzz of conversation is swirling around me. I feel at home. My headphones are on, my feet up next to the fireplace, and a warm cup of green tea is sitting beside me. What lies in front of me is a 90-minute focused time block to write these final words, and the feeling of completing a vision I've had since I was a kid: to write a book.

I am forever grateful to my past self who had the courage to face his fears, decide that the status quo didn't work for him, and who began to design his life with intention.

My goal in 2018 was to break out of corporate work. I didn't much care how; that was the goal. The time I created at work allowed me to build a business that leveraged some of my past skills in internet content and advertising. That was the exit vehicle.

I built sites read by millions. I replaced my corporate salary and grew the business afterwards but I didn't LOVE it. It gave me freedom and autonomy to do the things I wanted to do: work from home, not travel, take my kids to school, be present, coach them, take some vacations, etc.

Something was still missing. I revisited the principles in this book to examine how I was allocating my time, so that I could continue to direct focused effort on answering the biggest questions in my life:

- What is the best version of me?
- What's the one problem I care about so much that it is deserving of all the time I will spend working?
- How can I make work fun?
- What is inside of me that needs to come out?
- What do I want to teach my kids so they are equipped to deal with life?

Through the process of making time to examine these questions, and the space to experiment with them, I discovered my purpose in life. I began to utilize talents that laid dormant for decades.I began to give myself permission to create, tinker, fail and learn. And I began to trust my intuition about my work direction, and use my brain as the architect to make it happen.

Today, I spend all of my time working on the biggest problem I believe that exists today: how do really smart, hard-working, successful people find themselves trapped by the golden

handcuffs? How can they change their circumstances when they have so many responsibilities that almost make the thought of change sound insane?

People come to me in their forties, fifties, even sixties with the acute feeling that they've been spending their entire lives going through the motions. Operating on someone else's schedule, for someone else's dream. And they desperately need to know what they are actually capable of in this world before their time runs out.

These people come to me on the road to burnout, anxiety, depression, poor physical health, horrible self worth, neglected children, and broken marriages. All because of their warped relationship with the work they've been doing for the last thirty years.

I coach these people to BREAK that corporate dependence hanging over them, so they can begin building self-directed lives and businesses that bring them alive. The ability to change is the single greatest skill I can leave to my three boys, and change in this circumstance is where I can learn the most, so I can shape them. That's what drives me.

I don't run a multi-million dollar coaching program. I don't do events all over the world like Tony Robbins. I don't travel giving speeches, or sit in rooms where people talk about how important they are. I say "no" to business opportunities every single year that could add to my finances and my net worth.

Why? Because I don't want to.

I designed my life and my businesses so I can:

- Work from home
- Write from this coffee shop every single morning
- Work out at noon
- Take my kids to school
- Pick them up if they are sick or have a problem (major dad flex)
- Coach them and travel to every single practice, workout or game
- "Waste" time meeting with total strangers who reach out, just because
- "Take off" whenever I want

I have a beautiful home with a pool, a basketball court, and plenty of room for the kids to get into trouble. I teach entrepreneurship at a local college. I mow my own lawn in the summers and build an ice rink in the winters.

My time is most valuable doing these things. I don't care what all the time-management gurus say. I own my time. I am time sovereign. My story isn't unique. In fact, stories like mine are happening every day as the self-directed renaissance continues to grow.

By reading this short book, I hope you realized something profound about yourself: that you are the gatekeeper. I don't care what you want to do with your life. I only care that you realize that whatever it is, won't happen unless YOU become Time Sovereign. There's no

productivity hack, no magic system, no earth shattering opportunity that will get dropped in your lap. It’s YOU vs every distraction that takes your focus off your long term vision.

Time sovereignty isn't a destination but a pathway of powerful personal and professional growth. Each layer of freedom reveals new possibilities for you to step into a higher version of yourself. The ultimate goal isn't to reach some final state of perfect time-management, but to develop the capacity for ongoing change and adaptation—perhaps the most valuable skill we can cultivate in today's rapidly evolving world.

By claiming sovereignty over your time, you don't just change your schedule. You create space to become who you truly want to be. You must allow this journey to unfold. You must go with it. You must see where it can take you.